

Disconnected?

SINCE I WORK FROM HOME, HERE IN PERTH, AUSTRALIA, AND AM NOT REALLY THE OUT-DOORSY TYPE (EXCEPT WHEN I GO ON VACATION), I SPEND ALMOST ALL OF MY TIME AT HOME.

On the average work day, this is usually 23 hours a day (or more)! For someone like me, a mobile phone plan with a lot of data on it makes no real sense, because I would just never use it. If I go off on a road trip for a vacation, offline maps are more important because Australia only has proper cell reception in the cities and towns, and often none at all when travelling between them.

Like most people of the 21st century living in a big city, I took internet access totally for granted. I've written in this column before about joining a pilot project for 5G and being really happy with my connection. Usually I get speeds between 400 and 500 Mbps download, and between 30 and 40 Mbps upload, which is more than enough for any household, even one with as many devices, gadgets and screens as mine – something my wife constantly complains about. I have more than 40 individual devices that connect to the internet in my home, which is a little insane, but never tell my wife I admitted to that!

And boy was I reminded about how many things use the internet in my home on September 8. The first one to notice was my son, because he's the first to wake up in the morning, and usually grabs one of his iPads to play some silly game or watch an even sillier YouTube video. As soon as he realised he couldn't do any of those, everyone else was rudely awakened by his screams of indignation!

Assuming it to be a temporary problem we distracted him with other things and packed him off to school. After breakfast I called up to complain about the lack of service and was told that there was an upgradation of 5G towers happening, so it might take a day. Oh well, a day without the internet? Might be fun. It wasn't. I couldn't do any work, and I realised that I couldn't have any fun either because all my free time is spent online. It's all I know!

Thankfully I could use my phone to make calls and to chat with my colleagues on WhatsApp, so I just did that. However, the next day the net was still not back, and I got the same pathetic excuse. I'm pretty sure no one at work believed me – seeing as I live in a “developed country”, I don't

blame my colleagues for probably thinking I was just taking some time off.

After four days with no internet at home except my very limited mobile phone connection, I'd had enough! I called up a wired internet service provider about reconnecting me to the national broadband network (NBN) – Australia's rather pathetic fibre network, that uses copper for last mile connectivity. Yes, the very same connection I had spurned for 5G, and made fun of. Like most jilted lovers, the NBN planned to make me grovel before taking me back. They told me the earliest I could be re-connected was the 19th of September! “Surely the 5G will be working before then!”, my wife exclaimed.

It wasn't. When the 19th came along and I sheepishly rejoined the copper nightmare that the NBN is, my 5G connection was still down! We'd exhausted both our mobile data plans, and had fought with my 5G provider to get a free temporary 4G connection just for my son's iPad, and the TV so he could watch his cartoons (it's IPTV, so even that doesn't work without the internet!). I'd even started going to McDonald's parking lots, in order to use their free WiFi just to be able to join video calls for work!

The 5G problem with the tower close to my home was finally rectified on the 22nd of September, and 14 miserable days later, life returned to normal. Now I have two internet connections, and I plan to keep them both, because I just cannot be disconnected like that again. I know I'd never receive such pathetic service in India, because even during COVID-19 there would be people happily working away and doing their jobs, whereas here, people are a premium, and anything that needs a person to do takes forever! I've always laughed at anyone who thinks the service in India is bad, because honestly, we're treated like royalty there compared to here!

My two week disconnect did two very important things though. It's convinced me that the Internet should just be a basic right for all humans – we really should push the governments of the world to treat it exactly like that. And secondly, I've decided to relearn how to have fun without the Internet – I should get back to playing the guitar and reading books... only problem is all my books are on my Kindle, so I will have to de-Kindle to be able to rekindle that hobby without the internet... *sigh* 📖



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